

QA For Future Work

Q1: Why are there so many "9999" (Clearing Accounts)?

A: Since they persist even in May, it is possible that certain agencies habitually use "9999" for specific types of transactions. While these codes don't exist in the formal Budget Act, further investigations with each department would likely clarify which programs these funds should actually be attributed to.

Q2: What do you mean by "Non-budgetary items"?

A: These typically refer to expenditures authorized by sources other than the annual Budget Act, such as ongoing statutory requirements, federal mandates.

Q3: What is the main cause for the 1.2% unmatched records?

A: The primary cause is structural inconsistency in ID codes. For example, the third segment of a Budget ID is strictly 3 digits in the Budget Bill, but some expenditure records use 4 digits. Without manual verification for each case, these cannot be linked programmatically, so I categorized them as "unmatched".

Q4: 60% of items having "0%" utilization is surprising. Why is that?

A: It's important to note that "zero" doesn't always mean "no activity." In many cases, we see positive and negative entries that perfectly offset each other, resulting in a net zero. While the internal accounting logic for these offsets isn't fully transparent in this dataset, I have classified items with a final sum of zero as 0% utilization.

Q5: Does the CSL (State Library) case apply to other departments?

A: I expect similar patterns across other agencies, particularly regarding internal "Support" costs like personnel. However, I have focused my detailed verification on CSL as a representative case study and have not yet confirmed the specifics for every other department.

Q6: How much do the "over 100%" items actually exceed their budget?

A: Most of them, including the Tire Recycling program, hover around 120%. However, there are extreme outliers where the utilization rate reaches as high as 800%.

Q7: Isn't it incorrect to compare 30 months of spending to a 12-month budget?

A: I filtered the data specifically for expenditures with a "Year of Enactment" of 2023. Based on my experience in public finance, it is common for spending authority to extend beyond a single fiscal year. In fact, the Open Fiscal data even shows records from the 1990s being settled in 2024.